The Smart Cube Uses Open Source to Deliver Custom Research and Analytics Services

The Smart Cube offers a range of custom research and analytics services to its clients, and relies greatly on open source to do so. The UK-headquartered company has a global presence with major bases in India, Romania, and the US, and employs more than 650 analysts around the world.

"The whole analytics ecosystem is shifting towards open source," says Nitin Aggarwal, vice president of data analytics, The Smart Cube. Aggarwal is leading a team of over 150 developers in India, of which 100 are working specifically on open source deployments. The company has customers ranging from big corporations to financial services institutions and management consulting firms. And it primarily leverages open source when offering its services.

Aggarwal tells *Open Source For You* that open source has helped analytics developments to be more agile in a collaborative environment. "We work as a true extension of our clients' teams, and open source allows us to implement quite a high degree of collaboration. Open source solutions also make it easy to operationalise analytics, to meet the daily requirements of our clients," Aggarwal states.

Three major trends in the analytics market that are being powered by open source

- **Advanced analytics ecosystem:** Whether it is an in-house analytics team or a specialised external partner, open source is today the first choice to enable an advanced analytics solution.
- **Big Data analytics:** Data is the key fuel for a business, and harnessing it requires powerful platforms and solutions that are increasingly being driven by open source software.
- **Artificial intelligence:** Open source is a key enabler for R&D in artificial intelligence.

Apart from helping increase collaboration and deliver operationalised results, open source reduces the overall cost of analytics for The Smart Cube, and provides higher returns on investments for its clients. The company does have some proprietary solutions, but it uses an optimal mix of open and closed source software to cater to a wide variety of industries, business problems and technologies.

"Our clients often have an existing stack that they want us to use. But certain problems create large-scale complex analytical workloads that can only be managed using open source technologies. Similarly, a number of problems are best solved using algorithms that are better researched and developed in open source, while many descriptive or predictive problems are easily solved using proprietary solutions like Tableau, QlikView or SAS," says Aggarwal.